Your body looks like it might fit against mine pretty well. When we stand too close to each

It says that on your fortune?

other I don't feel compelled to tell you to back out of my personal space. In fact, I feel more like

It does.

grabbing you. Like pulling you in by the waist and ripping your mask off and watching your expression

Why can't *I* have a fortune cookie?

as I sink my fangs into your neck—draining you until I'm full. I think about pulling your hair back

I never said you couldn't—here.

tight—watching you squirm, wiggle, writhe, suffer—suffer like I've suffered, suffer like I've suffered all

Hmmph.

this waiting: waiting for you to embrace me, waiting for you to appreciate me, waiting for you to tell

What does it say?

me that I'm all that you think about and that if you have to settle for *just* thinking about me for one

Practice now. It's only a matter of time before I never see you again.

more second you're going to burst into flames. Tell me—tell me to shut up and eat you whole.

Ouch. What's that supposed to mean?

Right here—right here on the street, in the park, in the car, in the mall, in the sewer, in the

I think you know what it means.

penitentiary, in my last, dying, desperate moment—take me by the hand—I'm about to incinerate

I don't think I want to know.

you—I feel a heat and I'm going to make you feel it too, then I'm going to spread your cells—your

You need to prove you can go without me. Every day.

ashes—all over the ocean, all over my backyard, all over my body—I'm going to soak myself in your

Prove I can go without you? That often? How the hell am I supposed to do that?

cells and I'll keep on soaking myself until I'm wrinkly—wrinkly in a tub overflowing with your

You're not as dumb as you think. I know you can let go.

liquid biology, your shadow anatomy, the outline of your ears and your nose like candy—I'm chewing

Double ouch. I'd rather not.

on you—I'm chewing on your bones and on my memories of you like jerky, and I'm not going to

It says to practice, you goof, not give up. Don't hide in this castle of delusion.

accept a No thanks, a No I don't wanna embrace, a No I don't wanna wait for you, a No I don't

Practice?

wanna wait for you to embrace me, a No I don't wanna touch you, a No I don't wanna need you, a No

Yes—practice.

I don't wanna need for you to touch me, because you belong to me—the you I knew is mine alone—

How do I practice not seeing someone?

I can't return you, and you can't return me, so buckle up and open wide. Choo choo! I don't care if

Close your eyes. Erase me. One piece at a time. Sacrifice the tether between us.

I'm a fork and you're soup—I'm grabbing you by the bowl. They're gonna hear me gulping from

Freedom lies ahead.

outer space.

...

…

…

Can I kiss you again?

Does kissing me sound even a little like sacrifice?

Admittedly—no.

You need to learn to resist.

I did… For a while. And a kiss isn't even all that bad. We could get way worse if you wanted…

I don't think so. In all honesty, I don't think your mind's got the material to construct

Sure, why not?

all that much. Sex is pretty complicated. Mentally producing it and then sustaining it too in any

Yeah?

serious kind of way is a lot less sexy—a lot more sad and lonely than you'd think… Don't believe me?

Mhmm. C'mere.

You're still trying, even as we speak? Sure—that's fine. Keep trying—that's not even one bit pathetic.

Ah—ahh—mmm…

Isn't it dark? Isn't it hard to see? Isn't my face like a blank coin—like a sheet of paper? But I guess you

Stop. Look at me.

can try extra hard to fill in the details—my hair, my nose, my mouth—hard not to remember that

I'm looking.

kind of thing, huh? But what about the color of my eyes—of my eyelashes—or the delectable way

No—really *look* at me.

the tendons in my neck would slide when I'd shift my face—you're trying to make me shift my face up

I—I'm trying.

at you—I know. How's the eye contact? Like eye contact with a sock—with a mirror—with your

It's not working?

right hand. Sure—maybe you feel something—something good enough to submerge you in the

No! I mean—I can make it work. I can!

deep-end for a while, but pay attention. Are you even fucking at this point? Now you're just trying to

You can't! How strange! How sad! And now you're RUNNING OUT OF TIME!

remember what I look like—trying to turn air into rock. It's a doomed effort, brother—pointless

No way you can't see me! No way!? Not even in your dreams—your memories—your

fantasies!? Not even in your mind, where you could've gone and seen anything you've ever wanted?

"If you're feeling overwhelmed in public, try pretending you're blind. Not in a parking lot or on the street or anything dangerous like that, but just along straight paths where you know you won't fall or risk falling or risk getting injured seriously even if you do fall. I find that, just like with how I take showers in the dark—you know how I like taking showers in the dark?—just like with that—it helps tremendously with the self-consciousness to just keep your eyes closed and pretend that no one can see you—pretend that you can't see anyone."

"Is this like how you used to pretend to be mute while we were in high school?"

"I feel like blind people are a lot more free than us, in a way, and I admit that that's a pretty stupid thing for someone to think, but it's true, no?"

"I don't know."

"I was pretending to be blind in this dream I had where I'd killed people. I was guilty—slit two poor innocent throats with a credit card like I was a super villain when they were only trying to help me to the front of a line. In the moment, murdering them felt completely natural and logical. I felt offended and silly and effeminate. I felt they needed to die for buying too much into my eccentric act. Somehow I'd managed to escape the scene even though I'd opened up those throats in front of a crowd of witnesses. There was some projectile bleeding and people got soaked… It might have been a festival, or parade….A sex party?

I felt instinctively that you were nearby. I was always searching for your insufferable Girl face regardless of the crowd or the setting and I thought that I spotted you getting stuffed by some sweaty, tall, greco-roman gods in a corner somewhere. Even though I wanted to search you out so that I could cry in front of you…I didn't—was an outlaw, after all, on the run."

"I vanished from the crime scene. Thing is…when the murders were broadcasted, I managed to evade public suspicion. The witnesses—they all thought I'd finally—coincidentally decided to commit suicide—right at the same general time as the murders—which was apparently why I was missing when the police arrived—so I had this alibi everyone believed—this strange…collectively agreed upon idea that I was suicidal and that I'd probably just gone and finally done it meaning there was no way I'd killed those people—because I was dead, too… I was clearly the culprit; dream logic is hard to pin down. Part of me thinks everyone knew, and simply wanted to delete my existence from public record.

Eventually, a pair of fedora and trenchcoat clad secret service agents discovered me, and were going to disappear me for good, relieving me of my guilt, but I woke up—escaped that reality before I could receive due punishment for my countless, irremediable sins."

"I'd never imagined my humanity falling so low, and you can only imagine my doubt when I woke up. Even with the facts of my reality dribbling in around me—I'm in bed, I'm not a killer, I haven't gone out in days—my guilty mind couldn't help but house a little suspicion at the true nature of my character. A little doubt about whether I could do it or not. About whether I actually *had* done it or not. Murdered."

"It *did* go away, thankfully. Soon as I'd showered and realized the only person I could kill is myself."

"Which got me wondering: if I could lucid-dream you up—get really intense with it and try and focus on you as being the setting, the plot, the central character, the conflict, *and* the theme, and not just vague human background—maybe I could convince myself you were real—if not for a long while, at least for a little."

"…"

"What?"

"So what's the point of that?"

"Points. Points. Always gotta be a point, doesn't there? I wonder sometimes if there just—isn't… For instance: this conversation. This lucid dream I'm having right now, with you, talking with your disembodied voice. Absolutely pointless. "

I ordered two massive pizza pies loaded with toppings as an emergency trauma recovery procedure for those last two nightmares. Girl is a persistent devil in my ear and she made an unwanted appearance in both the fortune cookie sex dream and the phony blindness credit card murder debacle. To make matters worse, the delivery guy took an enormous morality dump in my mouth when I went to pick up the food. I didn't tip because I'm completely broke and I was scamming an app for the pizzas, but I still felt bad when he interrogated me about why I hadn't left him any money when it was raining and a busy Friday night. I could see where he was coming from, but why did I have to feel bad about surviving? I wanted to tell him to crawl into a tight and narrow space and light it on fire, but I ended up apologizing over and over like a damn pushover.

It's a cliché at this point—loneliness not being a function of solitude. Doesn't matter how many people are around, or how many people say hello how are you good good. Everyone will vanish from this world without anyone else ever truly knowing them. Even with that obvious, immutable fact stitched into the nature of our reality, truth is—I'm itching for a good hug or kiss or *something*, always, as I'm sure a lot of people are, all around the world, constantly.

Before my pizza showed up I went to the terrace because I'd noticed this girl I sort of like but have never *really* talked to (but she seems attainable) heading there while coming back from a walk. I took a shower quickly, put on what I thought might be a cute outfit—came over. I figured that most people study for at least an hour, so if I showed up within that time frame she'd still be there.

I sat somewhere behind her so that she was facing away from me. It was an unintelligent decision, in retrospect, since my goal was to try and talk to her… Instead of correcting my error I self-consciously checked my face out in the reflection of my laptop screen, for deficiencies, or read

Remainder, by Tom McCarthy. I alternated between these two activities and occasionally stared at the back of her head—until she left.

After finishing the book I left, too.

Apparently the heart is a myogenic pacemaker, meaning that it can beat on its own without influence from an innervating nerve, or the nervous system as a whole for that matter. This ultimately means that it can be removed from someone's person and yet continue to beat.

Remainder's unhappy protagonist realizes fantasies are doomed to short circuit—to spiral out of careful control into disaster—what with their being too complicated to summon up and tightly grip with imagination alone. Sad to think that some things we resign to forget forever simply because they're easy to abandon—to mess up.

Sometimes I felt that there was something I didn't get—was incapable of understanding—about Girl, that'd leave a cold distance between us—a barrier.

Sometimes. Or maybe there wasn't, and it was imaginary then, or imaginary now.

.

Why do such a bad job of haunting me, P? I'm not asking for much—no—I want mind stuff—strong—something strong and permanent that I could wrap nice and tight around my brain—emboss on my brain—would be enough for me. You know I hunt for the real you everywhere—even in my dreams—day and night—in my fantasies—in my memories—real or filled in—so that we can interface a little: say hi, hey, i love you, i don't, that's fine, goodbye, wanna hug?, okay, but make it quick—but you dodge me every time, and it's like you don't even want me to find you…

I want you to find me.

No you don't.

hey—J—believe me, I do

i don't know you

mmm…are we roleplaying? same, then

get away from me

you're not curious why I'm talking to you?

i am—I'm not.

…

…

too late. we're bound to collide.

not sure what that's supposed to mean

…

i decline the invitation

what invitation?

the invitation to fall in love with you, obviously

you don't believe my feelings are genuine?

...

Why? Why not? I'm not so bad, am I? You don't like me?

No, you're not so bad. You're exactly what I imagine. Imagined...I like you, how couldn't I?

OK. Then what's the matter?

...

...

...

...

What's the matter?

...

Seriously, man, what's the matter? Remember that this is all you, here. You're controlling this. What's the—

—Is there somebody else, P?

...

There's somebody else, isn't there.

...

tell me, tell me, just tell me, i know you can tell me.

...

Yes

Ok then

Sure, yeah, that's fine

Uh-huh

It's fine

...

Really—*it's fine*—it's just that I don't wanna be some secondary tertiary quaternary option, is why I declined the invitation, is what's the matter

Oh

Who is—

No, stop it, no, I won't do that, I don't wanna do that

Please? Please, you're going to break my cold little heart if you don't say. My fragile little baby heart.

I'm joking, obviously. I can handle it

just tell me who it is please i don't know why i need to know but i need to know so tell me—

You

What do you mean You

You. You're somebody else

I don't follow

I just don't love people, okay? It's not in my code. I'm not allowed. I don't deserve nor desire. I don't deserve desire, desire to deserve, no permutation fits none not a single one.

I'm still not following

I don't actually have a face, J.

Okay well what if I come close like this—

Stop it, you need to understand

...

I said stop it! You really don't get it!? Why do you insist on hurting yourself like this!? *You're* in control and you imagine *this*? *This* is what we get? How we interact? *My* words are *YOUR* words, stupid! My body, my presence... It's like liquid—like vapor. It's fluid, it has no real shape. I'm not enclosed. I'm not real. You can't make me real, no matter how hard you try, and you're trying hard, and even with all this power—you're pissing in the sandbox. You're stomping on the castles, and I guess what I'm trying to say is I just don't get it. Why are you letting me say that I don't get it?

ehh I won't stop it

Stop it

I won't stop it

I'm uncomfortable

Then why haven't you moved?

I'm scared.

You don't sound scared

I'm no wimp

How does this feel, then? Standing eye to eye like this—how do you feel?

I don't feel anything, dummy. Eye contact with you is like eye contact with a car window.

You liar, you're lying, stop lying!

I never lie

Ha!

About important things I never lie—I told you that—the *real* me told you that, and I guess that's part of—has become the complex you've developed around her, and it must be why I can't really embrace you, and it must be why you make me resist—you wanna work for it—even for a fantasy you wanna work for it like it's real, because that's how it worked in real life, right?

Right?

What do you mean You're somebody else

It's not in my code to say

Oh please—screw the code! I said screw the code! Love me, Parker! Love me, please! Make it real! Make it real! I wanna feel you! I don't remember what it feels like to feel something that hard—that much!

You say all that but…

Would you stop looking into my eyes so much? Seriously…

But I like looking into your eyes

…

I like that they're green. Green is cool. Don't typically notice a green like that just walking on the street—sitting on the bus. But up close they're—they remind me of a Windows 7 background. They're like if a green little martian had a white little fist, and then opened its fist to reveal a handful of shiny green coins.

Uhh

I, I don't mean—

You like my eyes?

I think they're cool

Hmmph

Yup

Do you think I'm beautiful?

Uh

What's the problem?

I would never call a woman the b word to her face

Hmmph

Do you know how to kiss?

Here we fuckin go

Do you know how to kiss?

Don't dare, don't you dare, I'll knock you out, don't you dare

I dare, shut up, I dare

No stop it's not in my code it's—

Get out of here with the code bullshit! You have to be able to reprogram it, hack it—something. I know you can do *something*. For me, for old times' sake. Let me feel it just one more time. One more time—for real.

...Fine.

—Fine?

Dare then, I yield. Have me. Kiss me. Do it. Make it work. If you can make it work—make it work.

It didn't work, but that's fine—fine because the upper bound of my loneliness is night, and the lower bound is morning. It's morning—afternoon—same thing—meaning I can only be so sad.

I think sometimes about a sadness delicious enough to be worth entertaining seriously during the day, but I've never had to deal with anything like that—no mom death, no lover death, no personal death—nothing. It's fucked up to wanna revel in the intensity of that kind of pain—like playing with a scab or a wound or something—but I still play with the different scenarios in my mind, is why even though I'd landed on heads, heads meaning go and tails meaning no and so I could've leapt over the railing of the top lot of this terribly tall parking garage—if I really wanted—instead I invested in the pain of that last fantasy interaction, an interaction so masochistically yummy in its denial of every one of my attempts at reliving that ancient kiss burning out my eyes (Isn't this your life? Yes—it is!) that I ate and ate and ate until I was absolutely stuffed with suffering, and it was a good enough hurt to satisfy the demands of the coin—of my luck—of the rules of my personal universe.

And there was all that untrustworthy but nevertheless bright light on my back—boosting my serotonin in intervals that grew and receded with the cloud cover. I'd hit a particularly long patch of sun, and every time I'd felt like it was about to phase itself out it didn't—it stayed—stayed after every one of my internal clock's abstract predictions: *now—is it gonna darken now? no? okay well how about...now? no?*—and in a way it probably represented hope or something, hope that was supposed to be gone but was still there—defiant—defying the comfortable trepidation I'd sunk into—ready for the hope and for the light to dim like they inevitably would—would dim—get replaced by darkness.

I couldn't help but wear a cynical smile when it finally did darken. The Brightness felt like an affront to my personal strife and struggle, after all.

Of course, it was only a matter of time before that darkness was phased out too, the clouds having cleared out to light up my world with the sun's relentless love.

Indirectly writing about the same person every night is an unintelligent way of forgetting about them. You could argue that it isn't a real strategy at all.

I know. I'm sorry. It's a love story—this is a love story—obviously, and I was trying to do it justice with this or that strategy and I'm realizing strategizing's dumb.

I'll tell it like how it needs to be said—that is to say—I'll just tell it how it is.

I've been draggin you around. Across time. Across place. Across all sorts. I'm the shy type. That's how I like to operate.

But I'm more or less ready to divulge everything. No more dragging you around the various lonely offices of my mind. Just the straight talk.

The final draft is missing. If I had to speculate, I'd suggest that it might possibly be in the possession of the girl it was directed at, or, maybe, that it's just recycled material somewhere, used over multiple cycles at this point so that the draft is completely indistinguishable—unidentifiable as love letter, letter, paper, etc., or, if we want to be pessimistic, it ended up somewhere much worse; it's trash—garbage—sitting at the bottom of some unemptied garbage can. While preparing it, I created a host of rough drafts, one of which has its introduction recorded on the torn-off back cover of my copy of D.F. Wallace's *The Broom of The System*. I have it, still—that rough draft. Still, by the way, is a cursed word, and might be my least favorite word.[1]

If she's thrown away my love letter, my final draft, I hope that it was at least into the recycling.

---

[1] The tough part about still loving someone who treats you like an afterthought… See? Still. Still is the ugliest word in that unfinished sentence. STILL STILL STILL. Unmoving. Unfinished. Still as stagnant as Never—is just as final.

Please be reminded that this is fiction. If I mention your name, or if you expect your name to be mentioned, please avert your eyes from the screen, document, whatever, and do not return. You are not allowed. I changed or added a few small things. Nothing that would impact meaning, or interpretation. It's not the love letter I wanted; it was a rough draft, after all. The language is too formal and stiff and the syntax is awkward, and it only moves me through nostalgia.

Parker,

My sister and my dad have never seemed close. I remember only vaguely all the fights and arguments. When my sister grew older the fights stopped. Now, their relationship is purely professional. Their contact consists solely of small talk.[2] Dispassionate conversation is the only type of engagement they bother to partake in.[3] Whenever I come to Ohio, I sleep on this black couch in the living room, which is set right next to my dad's office,[4] a mess of paper and folders. The only thing that appears even remotely deliberate in its placement is this frame my sister gave my dad as a Christmas present. It's always in the same spot, upright and taken care of among a sea of neglected books and office supplies. Inside the frame is a note my sister wrote my dad. I never cared to read it, that is until I started looking for inspiration. Something that could help me show you. Show you that I love you. Show you that I ache for you. Show you that I look for you everywhere.[5] Show you that I'm grateful beyond words for you even bothering to be around me. For caring about me. It broke my heart reading

---

[2] What a hideous sentence, I know.
[3] Oh God—yuck. Yuck—that one was worse.
[4] A dash or a colon would probably have been more effective, here, if not just straight up grammatically correct and so called for in terms of grammatical sense-making
[5] I'll admit that I enjoy rereading this part. I'm that kind of writer, you know? The kind that writes to reread. I'm satisfied if I can reread dozens of times and still feel I can read again without wincing, although the reason I enjoy rereading this section isn't because I think it's a particularly strong display of style or anything like that. It's just nice being sappy every now and again. Sometimes I hate it.

her note. Not because each word was perfect, each one was. Not because each sentence was beautiful, each one was. But because I could feel with each line how desperately she wanted to express her love for my dad, her appreciation. She knew that the small talk was the only way my father knew how to say I love you, because it is the only way she knows how to tell him. I hope this note can do the same thing for you. Don't feel bad that you may not be capable of making me understand how much you love me, because I know how impossible it is for me to make you understand [how much][6] I love you. The attempt is our small talk.[7]

[6] I'd hand-written each and every one of those love-letter-drafts. The reason I couldn't give her this particular draft—the *Broom* draft—was because I'd forgotten to include those two words, and I ran out of space because of my terrible handwriting and poor foresight. I'm a perfectionist—couldn't have given her the piece without it being exactly how I wanted it, even if it would've made passable—decent-enough sense, anyway... The final draft is way different. It evolved—had countless iterations—no shot you'd be able to recognize its roots in a draft as ancient as this one.

[7] Reference to John Green's *The Fault in Our Stars*. I lent her that book in eighth grade, when Green was blowing up—when everyone wanted to read it and figure out what everyone was literally crying about. I wrote in pencil on the inside cover, (which was black, although she could make out that there was indeed a message [she told me this later on]—it was completely illegible) *I, Jordan, like you! Do you like me, too?*

You're still there, huh..?

...

Well, you're not going to like this, but if you insist...

...

Remember when
Late at night
We agreed to meet in the park?
The dark water shimmered
like it was the moon and the ocean—not just a reservoir and a lamppost.

...

A serious artist was at work in the sky. The clouds and the moon looked so real.

...

I took off my glasses—
Chucked them into the lake?

You asked me why?—aren't you blind?
And I told you that if it was meant to be, they'd come back to me?

...

I was practicing never seeing you again.